

# Diagnosis Pocket Companion

Vital Substances · Eight Principles · The 28 Pulses  
EAM310 · Weeks 1–3

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## How this book works

Every entry has two parts.

**Top — what Schrier taught.** Straight from the lecture slides and transcripts. This is what gets examined.

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### BOTTOM — PLAIN LANGUAGE

Drawn from outside references to make the thing easier to actually *feel* or picture. Use it to build intuition; use the top half to answer questions.

*sources named per entry*

**Own these five first:** Floating · Deep · Slow · Rapid · Full. Schrier's Week 3 instruction, verbatim. Everything else is for the written exam.

**The pulse never stands alone.** Think Rapid? Ask about thirst, heat, sweating; look for a red tongue with yellow coat. Think Slow? Ask if they run cold. The pulse confirms — it does not decide.

**PART ZERO · WEEK 1**

# **Vital Substances Patterns**

氣血津液精 — Qi · Blood · Fluids · Essence,  
Deficiency & Excess

Deficiency, Stagnation, Stasis, and Excess patterns for each Vital Substance — the foundation everything in Weeks 2–3 builds on. 17 entries.

# Qi Deficiency

氣虛 Qì Xū

## PRESENTS AS

Slight shortness of breath, weak voice, spontaneous sweating, poor appetite, loose stools, tiredness (physical AND mental). Empty pulse.

## ARISES FROM

More Qi consumed than the body can produce — overuse from illness, overwork, excessive sport/fitness training, excessive physical & mental activity, lack of sleep, or insufficient/poor-quality food. Most often involves Lung, Spleen, Kidney, Heart.

## KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Fatigue is the hallmark, and it shows up both physically and mentally — not just tired muscles, a tired mind too.

## IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Qi is the body's working capital. Spend faster than you earn it and the account runs low everywhere at once.

# Sinking Qi

氣陷 Qì Xiàn

## PRESENTS AS

Same base signs as Qi Deficiency, plus a feeling of bearing down, prolapse of an organ, mental depression, listlessness.

## ARISES FROM

An aspect of Qi Deficiency specifically — not enough Yang Qi to rise and ascend. Spleen is the primary organ affected.

## KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Qi Deficiency signs plus a literal 'things are falling' sensation (organ prolapse, bearing-down feeling) is Sinking, not plain Deficiency.

## IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Qi normally holds things up against gravity. Deficient enough, and it stops fighting gravity altogether.

## Qi Stagnation

氣滯 Qì Zhì

### PRESENTS AS

Distention (subjective & objective), pain that moves and comes/goes with emotional state, mental depression, irritability, 'gloomy' feeling, frequent mood swings, frequent sighing, Wiry pulse, tongue normal or slightly red on the sides.

### ARISES FROM

A common pathogenic factor, most often affecting the Liver (also Lungs, Heart, Stomach, Spleen, Intestines). Internal cause: emotional stress. Miscellaneous causes: irregular eating, excessive physical work, lack of exercise.

### KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Distention outweighs pain, and both come and go with mood — that rhythm is the tell.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Think of Qi as traffic. Stagnation is a jam, not a closed road — pressure builds, eases, then builds again.

# Rebellious Qi

氣逆 Qì Nì

## ARISES FROM

Qi moving in the opposite of its normal physiological direction for that organ.

| Organ   | Normal   | Pathological                  | Signs                                                                                         |
|---------|----------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Stomach | Downward | Upward                        | Belching, hiccup, nausea, vomiting                                                            |
| Spleen  | Upward   | Downward                      | Diarrhoea, prolapse                                                                           |
| Liver   | Upward   | Excess up / horizontal / down | Headache, dizziness, irritability, nausea, vomiting, diarrhoea, dry stools, burning urination |
| Lungs   | Downward | Upward                        | Cough, asthma                                                                                 |
| Kidneys | Downward | Upward                        | Asthma                                                                                        |
| Heart   | Downward | Upward                        | Mental restlessness, insomnia                                                                 |

## IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Every organ's Qi has a commute route. Rebellious Qi is that commute running backwards — you can't diagnose it without knowing the NORMAL direction first.

## Blood Deficiency

血虛 Xuè Xū

### PRESENTS AS

Dull-white/sallow complexion, dizziness, poor memory, numbness/tingling, blurred vision, insomnia, pale lips, scanty periods or amenorrhoea, depression, slight anxiety, pale/thin/slightly dry tongue, Choppy or Fine pulse.

### ARISES FROM

Inadequate intake of blood-rich foods, deficiency in blood-producing organs, blood loss via bleeding, consumption by excess mental or physical activity.

### KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Signs cluster around dryness, pallor, and a mind that can't settle — insomnia, poor memory, anxiety are as diagnostic as the pale tongue.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Blood is Qi's cargo: nourishment, moisture, and a stable home for the mind. Run the cargo low and everything downstream turns dry and unsettled.



## Blood Stasis — Overview

血瘀 Xuè Yū

### PRESENTS AS

Stabbing/fixed/boring pain, dark complexion, purple lips/nails, bleeding with dark clots, dark menstrual blood with clots, fixed abdominal masses, Wiry/Choppy/Firm pulse, purple tongue.

### ARISES FROM

Qi Stagnation, Qi Deficiency, Heat in the Blood, Blood Deficiency, Interior Cold, Dampness & Phlegm, Trauma, Emotions, Diet, Lifestyle habits.

### KEY DISCRIMINATOR

FIXED and STABBING — location doesn't move and pressure doesn't relieve it, unlike Qi Stagnation's wandering, distending pain. Potentially the cause of serious disease: cancer, abdominal masses, fibroids, endometriosis, heart disease, stroke (Maciocia 2015).

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

If Qi Stagnation is a traffic jam, Blood Stasis is a stalled car blocking the lane entirely — same road, but now nothing moves through that exact spot.

# Qi Stagnation vs. Blood Stasis

氣滯 vs 血瘀

| Feature          | Qi Stagnation              | Blood Stasis                     |
|------------------|----------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Pain/distension  | More distension than pain  | More pain than distension        |
| Location         | Moving                     | Fixed                            |
| Character        | Distending pain            | Boring, stabbing pain            |
| Abdominal masses | Appearing and disappearing | Fixed                            |
| Skin             | Not appearing on skin      | May show purple blotches/bruises |
| Face             | May be unchanged           | Dark colour or bluish-green      |
| Tongue           | Normal or slightly red     | Purple, especially on the sides  |
| Pulse            | Wiry                       | Wiry, Firm, or Choppy            |

## IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same neighborhood, different problem. Qi Stagnation is pressure that moves; Blood Stasis is a fixed obstruction. The face and skin often tell you before the pulse does.

## Blood Stasis — Liver & Heart

肝 · 心

### PRESENTS AS

**Liver:** purple nails, dark face, painful periods with dark clots, abdominal pain, premenstrual pain, purple tongue (especially sides), Wiry or Firm pulse.

**Heart:** purple lips, stabbing/pricking chest pain, mental restlessness, purple tongue (sides toward front), purple/distended sublingual veins, Choppy or Knotted pulse.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Liver Blood Stasis shows up in the cycle and the belly.  
Heart Blood Stasis shows up in the chest and under the tongue.

## Blood Stasis — Lung, Stomach, Intestines & Uterus

肺 · 胃 · 腸 · 子宮

### PRESENTS AS

**Lung (Upper Burner):** chest oppression, coughing dark blood, purple tongue sides toward front, distended sublingual veins.

**Stomach (Middle Burner):** epigastric pain, vomiting dark blood, dark blood in stools, tongue purple in the center.

**Intestines (Lower Burner):** dark blood in stools, severe abdominal pain, purple tongue at the rear.

**Uterus (Lower Burner):** painful periods, dark menstrual clots, amenorrhea, fixed abdominal masses.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same purple-tongue, fixed-pain signature everywhere — only the tongue ZONE and the bleeding site change with the organ.

## Heat in the Blood

血熱 Xuè Rè

### PRESENTS AS

Feeling of heat, skin diseases with red eruptions, thirst, bleeding, red tongue, rapid pulse. **Heart:** anxiety, restlessness, mouth ulcers. **Liver:** itchy skin diseases with heat/redness. **Uterus:** excessive period blood loss. **Intestines:** blood in stools.

### ARISES FROM

Invasion of Heat penetrating from exterior down to the Ying/Blood level (Four Levels), or internally generated from excess Heat in Liver or Heart.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Heat doesn't just warm Blood, it agitates it — pushing it out of its vessels (bleeding) and out through the skin (eruptions).

## Loss of Blood

失血 Shī Xuè

### PRESENTS AS

Bloody nose, vomiting blood, coughing up blood, blood in stool, menorrhagia, metrorrhagia, blood in urine.

### ARISES FROM

Two main causes: (1) Qi Deficiency, unable to hold Blood in its vessels; (2) Blood Heat pushing Blood out of the vessels. Two less common causes: Blood Stasis, Yin Deficiency.

### KEY DISCRIMINATOR

Ask WHY blood is escaping — a Deficient/holding problem (Qi) or a Heat/agitation problem (Heat) point to opposite treatment principles.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Blood needs two things to stay put: Qi to hold it in, and calm to keep it from being pushed out. Loss of Blood means one of those failed.

## Deficiency of Body Fluids

津液虧虛

### PRESENTS AS

**Lung:** dry skin, dry cough. **Stomach:** dry tongue with horizontal cracks, dry mouth without desire to drink (or small sips). **Kidney:** scanty urination, dry mouth at night, dry throat. **Large Intestine:** dry stool.

### ARISES FROM

Associated with Yin — deficiency always causes dryness. Caused by dietary factors, Yin deficiency, heavy blood loss, profuse sweating, vomiting, diarrhea, or severe Blood deficiency.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Body Fluids are Yin's water supply. Deplete them and every organ that depends on moisture dries out in its own characteristic way.

## Edema

水腫 Shuǐ Zhǒng

### PRESENTS AS

Swelling from fluid retention outside the cells — fluid leaking from its normal pathways into the space between skin & muscles. **Pitting:** deficiency of Yang of Spleen, Lungs, and/ or Kidneys. **Non-pitting:** Qi stagnation or Dampness.

### ARISES FROM

By organ — Lung Yang deficiency: edema of face & hands. Spleen Yang deficiency: abdomen & limbs. Kidney Yang deficiency: lower body, legs & ankles.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Pitting edema is a Yang-power problem (not enough heat to move fluid). Non-pitting is a traffic problem (Qi or Damp blocking the road).



## Phlegm — Substantial vs. Non-Substantial

痰 Tán

### PRESENTS AS

**Substantial:** can be seen — e.g. sputum collected in the Lungs and spat out. **Non-substantial:** retained subcutaneously or in the channels; can obstruct Heart orifices or Gall Bladder/Kidneys (as stones); can settle in joints as arthritic bone deformities.

### ARISES FROM

Spleen deficiency is the main cause; Lungs & Kidneys also involved (Lung fails to diffuse/lower fluids; Kidney fails to transform/excrete fluids).

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Substantial Phlegm is the Phlegm you can cough up. Non-substantial is the same mechanism hiding somewhere you can't see it — why it explains so many 'mystery' presentations.

## Types of Substantial Phlegm

痰 — 有形

### PRESENTS AS

**Damp:** profuse sticky white phlegm, chest/epigastric oppression, nausea, sticky taste, no thirst, Slippery pulse.

**Heat:** sticky yellow phlegm, red face, dry mouth, restlessness, Rapid-Slippery pulse.

**Cold:** white-watery phlegm, cold limbs, nausea, Deep-Slippery-Slow pulse.

**Wind:** unilateral numbness, rattling throat, aphasia, deviated tongue, Wiry pulse.

**Fluid:** very thin watery sputum, dizziness, Wiry pulse.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same underlying Phlegm mechanism, five flavors depending on which pathogen rode along — color and consistency of what's coughed up is the fastest clue.

# Types of Non-Substantial Phlegm

痰 — 無形

## PRESENTS AS

**Qi Phlegm:** throat-swelling sensation (no visible swelling), difficulty swallowing, chest oppression, moodiness.

**Under the Skin:** lumps, swollen lymph nodes/thyroid, lipoma.

**In the Channels:** numbness.

**Misting the Heart:** mental illness.

**Gallbladder & Kidneys:** stones.

**In the Joints:** bone deformities in chronic rheumatoid arthritis.

## IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A throat lump, a lipoma, a stone, even some mental illness — all trace to the same invisible Phlegm, just settling in a different location each time.

## Essence (Jing) Deficiency

精虛 Jīng Xū

### PRESENTS AS

**In children:** poor bone development, late closure of fontanelle, mental dullness/retardation.

**In adults:** softening of bones, weakness of knees & legs, lower backache, poor memory, loose teeth, falling hair or premature greying, weakness of sexual activity, infertility, sterility, tinnitus, deafness, absent-mindedness, decreased mental sharpness.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Jing is the fixed capital you were born with. Deficiency in a child looks like development that never fully switches on; in an adult it looks like premature aging.

# Eight Principles

八纲 Bā Gāng — 表里 · 寒热 · 虚实 · 阴阳

**Four axes, not eight boxes.** Every patient sits somewhere on each of:  
Exterior/Interior (where) · Cold/Heat (nature) · Deficiency/Excess (strength) · Yin/Yang (the summary of the other three).

| Axis                       | Fastest test                                              |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Exterior / Interior</b> | Simultaneous chills AND fever + Floating pulse = Exterior |
| <b>Cold / Heat</b>         | Thirst, drink preference, urine colour, tongue coat       |
| <b>Deficiency / Excess</b> | Pressure: relieved = Deficiency · aggravated = Excess     |
| <b>Yin / Yang</b>          | Read off the other three                                  |

**Schrier's formulas:** Yang def = Qi deficiency signs + cold. Yin def = Blood deficiency signs + heat.

## Exterior

表 Biǎo

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### PRESENTS AS

Aversion to cold and fever occurring TOGETHER, aching body, stiff neck, Floating pulse. Sudden onset, short duration, early stage.

### ARISES FROM

Invasion of the superficial portion of the body by an exogenous pathogen.

#### Key discriminator

The pairing is everything. The moment the aversion to cold disappears while fever persists, the pathogen has moved Interior.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Think of the body as a walled city under attack from outside. Fighting at the wall makes you feel both the cold outside and the heat of the battle at once — that simultaneity is the whole diagnosis.

*Kaptchuk · Maciocia*

## Interior

里 Lǐ

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### PRESENTS AS

No simultaneous aversion to cold, Deep pulse. Located in the five Zang and six Fu.

### ARISES FROM

Either an exterior pathogen transmitted inward, or functional disturbance of the Zang-Fu themselves.

#### Key discriminator

Interior also tells you the DIRECTION of travel. Exterior → Interior means the disease is advancing.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Exterior/Interior isn't strictly anatomical depth — it's a statement about where the fight is happening and which way it's moving.

*Maciocia*

## Exterior Cold

表寒

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### PRESENTS AS

Slight fever, pronounced aversion to cold, severe body aches, severe stiff neck, NO sweating, no thirst. Floating-Tight pulse, thin white coating.

### ARISES FROM

Wind-Cold invasion.

#### Key discriminator

No sweating plus severe aches is the Full Exterior picture.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Cold contracts. The pores shut (no sweat), the muscles seize (severe aches), the vessel tightens (Tight pulse). One mechanism, three signs.

*Kaptchuk*



## Exterior Heat

表热

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### PRESENTS AS

Fever, mild aversion to cold, sore throat, thirst. Floating-Rapid pulse.

### ARISES FROM

Wind-Heat invasion.

#### Key discriminator

Sore throat is the reliable early differentiator from Exterior Cold.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Heat rises and disperses — so it shows first at the top and outside: throat, head, skin.

*Maciocia*

## Full Exterior

表实

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### PRESENTS AS

Fever, NO sweating, severe body aches, aversion to cold. Floating-Tight pulse, thin white coating.

### ARISES FROM

Strong pathogen meeting strong Zheng Qi.

#### Key discriminator

No sweating = Full.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The gate is shut and both armies are strong. Nothing is leaking out.

*Maciocia*

## Empty Exterior

表虚

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### PRESENTS AS

Slight or NO fever, sweating present, aversion to WIND, slight body aches.  
Floating-Slow pulse, thin white coating.

### ARISES FROM

Weak Wei Qi failing to secure the exterior.

#### Key discriminator

Sweating plus aversion to wind rather than cold.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The gate won't close. Sweat escapes, and moving air feels intolerable because there's no defence at the surface.

*Maciocia*

## Full Cold

实寒

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### PRESENTS AS

Feeling cold, cold limbs, no thirst, pale face, abdominal pain  
AGGRAVATED by pressure, desire for warm drinks, loose stools, clear abundant urine. Deep-Full-Tight pulse, Pale tongue with THICK white coating.

### ARISES FROM

Excess of Yin. Cold foods, iced drinks, or external Cold penetrating inward.

#### Key discriminator

Face bright-white · pain sharp and worse on pressure · better after a bowel movement.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Something is physically there and obstructing — that's why pressure hurts. Excess always resents pressure.

*Maciocia FCM Table 30.2*

## Empty Cold

虚寒

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### PRESENTS AS

Feeling cold, cold limbs, DULL pale face, no thirst, listlessness, sweating, loose stools, clear abundant urine. Deep-Slow or Weak pulse, Pale tongue with THIN white coating.

### ARISES FROM

Deficiency of Yang. Overwork, inadequate warm food, excessive sexual activity, internal Cold injuring Yang.

#### Key discriminator

Face dull-white · pain dull and BETTER on pressure · worse after a bowel movement.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Nothing is there to obstruct — the problem is absence. Pressure adds the support that's missing, so it helps.

*Maciocia FCM Table 30.2*

## Full Heat

实热

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### PRESENTS AS

Thirst, feeling of heat, mental restlessness, RED FACE (whole face), dry stools, scanty dark urine. Rapid-Full pulse, Red tongue with YELLOW coating.

### ARISES FROM

Excess Yang. Emotional problems; diet (red meat, spices, alcohol); an exterior pathogen penetrating inward and transforming to Heat.

#### Key discriminator

High fever · very restless and agitated · profuse sweating · loud voice · thirst for cold drinks.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A fire with fuel. Loud, red, dry, and outward. Everything about it is additive.

*Maciocia*

## Empty Heat

虚热

### PRESENTS AS

Heat in the afternoon or evening, dry mouth wanting small sips, dry throat AT NIGHT, night sweating, five-palm heat (chest, palms, soles), dry stools, scanty dark urine. Floating-Empty-Rapid pulse, Red tongue with NO coating.

### ARISES FROM

Deficiency of Yin — Yin consumed over time, leaving Yang relatively in excess. Overwork, irregular eating, excessive sexual activity, heavy blood loss.

#### Key discriminator

MALAR FLUSH only, not whole face · low-grade afternoon fever · vague anxiety · thin red tongue, NO coating.

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Not a bigger fire — a smaller pond. The heat is relative, which is why it's timed (afternoon, night) rather than constant.

*Maciocia*

## Full / Excess

实 Shí

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### PRESENTS AS

Pain AGGRAVATED by pressure, forceful pulse, loud voice, robust build, agitation, thick tongue coating.

### ARISES FROM

A pathogenic factor is present and the body's Qi is still strong enough to fight it.

#### Key discriminator

Pressure response is the single fastest differentiator in the entire Eight Principles.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Excess = something present that shouldn't be. Deficiency = something absent that should be. Press: if it hurts more, something is there.

*Kaptchuk · Maciocia*



## Empty / Deficiency

虚 Xū

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### PRESENTS AS

Pain RELIEVED by pressure and warmth, weak pulse, quiet voice, fatigue, thin or no coating.

### ARISES FROM

The body's own Qi, Blood, Yin, or Yang is insufficient.

#### **Key discriminator**

Deficiency likes pressure. Excess resents it.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Same test, opposite answer. It works because you're asking whether adding is welcome or unwelcome.

*Kaptchuk*

## Yin Pattern

阴 Yīn

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### PRESENTS AS

Groups Interior + Cold + Deficiency. Quiet, slow, pale, cold, withdrawn, weak pulse.

### ARISES FROM

The master category — everything Yin-natured collapses into it.

#### **Key discriminator**

If you can place a patient on the other three pairs, Yin/Yang is already decided.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Yin/Yang isn't a fourth independent question — it's the summary of the first three.

*Kaptchuk*

## Yang Pattern

阳 Yáng

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### PRESENTS AS

Groups Exterior + Heat + Excess. Loud, fast, red, hot, agitated, forceful pulse.

### ARISES FROM

The master category for everything Yang-natured.

#### Key discriminator

Yang = faster, louder, more active. Yin = slower, quieter, less.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Use it as a sanity check: if you've called something Interior-Cold-Deficient, it should read as Yin overall. If it doesn't, re-examine.

*Kaptchuk*

## False Heat, True Cold

真寒假热

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### PRESENTS AS

Red cheeks but the colour is POWDER-LIKE and the rest of the face is white; irritability but also listlessness; wants to lie curled up; thirst but NO desire to drink, or wants WARM fluids; body feels hot but the patient wants to be COVERED; sore throat without redness or swelling; pale urine; quiet breathing, low voice. Pale wet tongue. Pulse Rapid, Floating, Big but EMPTY.

### ARISES FROM

Interior Cold forcing the remaining Yang outward and upward.

#### Key discriminator

This is NOT Empty-Heat. In Empty-Heat there really is Heat. Here the Heat appearance is false — there is no Heat at all.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

A dying fire flaring at the edges. The flare looks like heat but the hearth is cold. Ask about drinks and covers — the patient's own preference gives it away.

*Maciocia · Kaptchuk*

## False Cold, True Heat

真热假寒

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### PRESENTS AS

Dark face with BRIGHT eyes and 'spirit'; red-dry lips; irritability with a strong body; thirst WITH desire for cold fluids; scanty dark urine; constipation; burning in the anus; noisy breathing, loud voice. Red-dry tongue body. Pulse Deep and FULL — cold limbs but the CHEST IS HOT.

### ARISES FROM

Full Heat so intense it drives Yang inward and away from the extremities.

#### **Key discriminator**

Cold limbs but a hot chest. Feel the chest, not just the hands.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The furnace is roaring but the doors are shut, so the outside feels cool. Everything central — voice, eyes, thirst, urine — reports the real state.

*Maciocia · Kaptchuk*

## Cold Exterior, Heat Interior

表寒里热

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### PRESENTS AS

Fever with aversion to cold, no sweating, headache and stiff neck, body aches (exterior Cold) PLUS irritability and thirst (interior Heat).

### ARISES FROM

Pre-existing interior Heat, then invaded by exterior Wind-Cold.

#### Key discriminator

Both pictures are genuinely present — this is not a false appearance.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Two real problems stacked, not one problem in disguise. Treat both.

*Maciocia*

## Heat Exterior, Cold Interior

表热里寒

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### PRESENTS AS

Fever with aversion to cold, sore throat, thirst, headache, Floating-Rapid pulse PLUS loose stools, chilliness, profuse pale urine.

### ARISES FROM

Pre-existing Cold condition, then attacked by exterior Wind-Heat.

#### Key discriminator

Upper/outer Heat signs with lower/inner Cold signs.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Mirror image of the above. Again both are real.

*Maciocia*

## Heat Above, Cold Below

上热下寒

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### PRESENTS AS

Above: thirst, irritability, sour regurgitation, bitter taste, mouth ulcers.

Below: loose stools, borborygmi, profuse pale urine.

### ARISES FROM

Heat rises, Cold descends — they separate rather than mixing.

#### Key discriminator

Mouth ulcers with loose stools is the classic pairing.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Heat naturally goes up and Cold naturally goes down, so when both exist they stratify. The body layers rather than averages.

*Maciocia*



## Combined Heat and Cold

寒热错杂

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### PRESENTS AS

Manifestations of both simply coexisting.

### ARISES FROM

Extremely common in practice — e.g. Kidney-Yang deficiency with Damp-Heat in the Bladder, or Spleen-Yang deficiency with Liver-Fire.

### Key discriminator

Don't force a single label. Real patients are frequently both.

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### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The Eight Principles are axes, not boxes. A patient occupies a position on each one independently.

*Kaptchuk*

# Pulse Diagnosis

脈診 — The 28 Qualities

## Before you palpate

| Do                                    | Why                                           |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Ask permission, every time            | Non-negotiable — and it settles them          |
| Arm horizontal, not above heart level | Bends impede flow                             |
| Index=Cùn, middle=Guān, ring=Chǐ      | Middle finger always on Guān                  |
| All three fingers down first          | Overall impression before positions           |
| Your right hand → their left wrist    | Reverse if seated same-side                   |
| Let them settle                       | Stairs, cold, a heavy meal all move the pulse |
| Note time and season                  | Both shift the pulse independent of pathology |
| Count against YOUR breath             | Breathe naturally — don't engineer it         |

**Fingers are not held still.** Still only when counting rate. Otherwise press/lift for depth, roll for length, push medial-lateral for shape.

## Three depths

| Depth              | How to find it                                   | Reflects   |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>Superficial</b> | Light contact, just the skin                     | Qi         |
| <b>Middle</b>      | Press to bone, obliterate, release <i>slowly</i> | Blood      |
| <b>Deep</b>        | Press to bone level                              | Yin organs |

### IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The middle is the one everyone skips because it has no landmark. Find your two anchors first — surface and bone — then travel slowly between them. The middle announces itself as a change, not as a place.

*Maciocia · Shen Hammer*

## Six positions — Nan Jing

|                                   | Left                                            | Right                                           |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| 寸 <b>Cùn</b><br>Upper<br>Burner   | Hand Taiyang / SI · Hand<br>Shaoyin / <b>HT</b> | Hand Yangming / LI · Hand<br>Taiyin / <b>LU</b> |
| 關 <b>Guān</b><br>Middle<br>Burner | Foot Shaoyang / GB · Foot<br>Jueyin / <b>LR</b> | Foot Yangming / ST · Foot<br>Taiyin / <b>SP</b> |
| 尺 <b>Chǐ</b><br>Lower<br>Burner   | Foot Taiyang / BL · Foot<br>Shaoyin / <b>KD</b> | Hand Shaoyang / TB · Hand<br>Jueyin / <b>PC</b> |

**Quick:** L = HT · LR · KD | R = LU · SP · PC

## Normal & seasonal

| 胃神根           | Means                                                    |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 胃 <b>Wèi</b>  | Flowing, gentle, harmonious movement                     |
| 神 <b>Shén</b> | Strong, rhythmical — vitality present in the beat        |
| 根 <b>Gēn</b>  | Depth felt at Chǐ — Kidney Qi intact under firm pressure |

**Rate:** 4–5 beats per your breath, 60–90 bpm.

| Season | Pulse                         | Dates         |
|--------|-------------------------------|---------------|
| Spring | <b>Wiry</b> 弦                 | Feb 4 – May 4 |
| Summer | <b>Flooding</b> 洪             | May 5 – Aug 6 |
| Autumn | <b>Hair-like / Floating</b> 毛 | Aug 7 – Nov 6 |
| Winter | <b>Stone / Deep</b> 石         | Nov 7 – Feb 3 |

**Seasonal ≠ normal automatically.** Only when nothing else corroborates pathology. Flooding in *winter* is a warning — Schrier's case ended in a fatal cerebral hemorrhage.

## Floating

浮 Fú

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### FEEL

Felt distinctly at the superficial depth; force decreases slightly deeper but never feels empty.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Wood floating on the surface of water; a subtle breeze across a bird's back; scallion leaves rolled lightly between the fingers.*

### INDICATES

Invasion of external Wind. Yin Deficiency (interior condition presenting superficially).

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Yin Def**: Exterior needs simultaneous chills AND fever.

### COMBINATIONS

**Floating-Weak** — External-Empty — weak Wei Qi failing to react properly to external pathogenic invasion

**Floating-Empty** — Summer-Heat invasion (floats MORE) vs. Yin Deficiency (floats less) — degree is the differentiator

**Floating-Slippery** — invasion of Wind-Damp, or Wind complicated by Phlegm

---

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Put a ping-pong ball in water and press it. It rises to meet your finger, dips when you push, springs back the moment you ease off. Or a boogie board floating in a pool — something is definitely there at the top, but little substance underneath. It comes UP to meet you rather than sitting under your finger.

### **Then what**

Now ask: chills and fever at the same time? Stiff neck? Stuffy nose? If yes — Exterior. If instead you get night sweats, hot palms and soles, a flushed patch on the cheeks, and a throat that's dry at night — that's Yin Deficiency wearing the same costume.

*Maciocia · Kaptchuk*

# Deep / Submerged

沉 Chén

## FEEL

Located deep next to the bone; barely felt with light or moderate pressure; only felt pressing to bone and tendons.

## CLASSICAL IMAGE

*A stone thrown into a well, sinking to the bottom.*

## INDICATES

Pathogenic factor in the Interior (Deep-Full). Yang Deficiency (Deep-Weak).

### Not to be confused with

vs **Hidden**: Hidden can't be found until bone-level pressure.

## COMBINATIONS

**Deep-Weak** — Yang Deficiency

**Deep-Wiry** — Blood Stasis, or a Chong Mai issue

**Deep-Wiry-Slow** — Blood stasis due to Cold, or Cold stagnating in the Liver channel

**Deep-Slow** — interior Cold

**Deep-Rapid** — interior Heat

**Deep-Soggy-Slow** — Dampness in the Interior

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Nothing at all on light touch — beginners often conclude there's no pulse. Keep pressing toward the bone and it appears. Like feeling for a stone at the bottom of a pond.

### Then what

Once you've found it, ask whether it's strong or weak down there. Deep + forceful = a pathogen sitting in the Interior. Deep + feeble = Yang Deficiency. Same depth, opposite treatment.

Maciocia

## Slow

遲 *Chí*

---

### FEEL

Fewer than three beats per breath, about 40–60bpm, regular rhythm.

### INDICATES

Cold pattern. Empty-Cold (Slow+Weak). Full-Cold (Slow+Full).

#### Not to be confused with

vs **Huǎn**: Slow is under 3/breath. Huǎn is 4 — and healthy.

### COMBINATIONS

**Slow-Floating** — exterior Wind-Cold with prevalence of Wind

**Slow-Deep** — interior Cold

**Slow-Slippy** — Cold-Phlegm or Damp-Cold

**Slow-Choppy** — Blood Deficiency and interior Cold

**Slow-Weak** — Empty-Cold with Yang Deficiency

**Slow-Full** — internal Cold, often chronic painful conditions

**Slow-Wiry** — stagnation of Cold in the Liver channel

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Not dramatic — just unhurried. You'll notice you're waiting between beats while breathing normally.

#### Then what

COUNT IT. Under 3 per breath is Slow. Four is Huǎn, which is healthy. This single count is the most common careless error in the whole unit.

*Maciocia*



## Rapid

數 Shuò

---

### FEEL

Over five beats per breath, 90–140bpm, regular rhythm.

### INDICATES

Heat pattern. Full-Heat (Rapid+Full). Empty-Heat (Rapid+Floating-Empty).

### COMBINATIONS

**Rapid-Full** — Full-Heat from Excess of Yang

**Rapid-Empty** — Empty-Heat from Deficiency of Yin

**Rapid-Fine / Rapid-Floating** — External Wind-Heat

**Rapid-Deep** — interior Heat

**Rapid-Overflowing** — Full-Heat

**Rapid-Wiry** — Liver-Fire

**Rapid-Slippery** — Phlegm-Heat

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It feels busy. You can't finish a comfortable breath before five or more beats have gone by.

#### Then what

Before calling it Heat, ask whether they rushed in, climbed stairs, or are anxious. Settle them two minutes and re-take. Exertion produces a rapid pulse that means nothing.

*Maciocia*

## Empty / Deficient

虛 Xū

### FEEL

Wide but without strength; forceless at all three positions under light or heavy pressure; a sense of emptiness.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*A water balloon — big on the outside, nothing solid when you press in.*

### INDICATES

Qi Deficiency.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Scattered**: Empty keeps its shape; Scattered loses it and can't be counted.

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A water balloon. Wide across, but press in and nothing solid pushes back. The vessel is broad and the content isn't filling it.

#### **Then what**

Confirm with the person, not the wrist: tired? short of breath? quiet voice? Does pressure on a sore spot feel GOOD? Deficiency welcomes pressure.

Schrier · Maciocia

## Full / Excessive

實 *Shí*

---

### FEEL

Felt at all three positions and all three depths; long, wide, and forceful.

### INDICATES

Full pattern. Full-Heat (Full+Rapid). Full-Cold (Full+Slow).

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Overflowing**: Full does not decay.

### COMBINATIONS

**Full-Rapid** — Full-Heat

**Full-Slow** — Full-Cold

**Full-Tight** — Full-Cold

**Full-Slippery** — Phlegm

**Full-Long** — Heat

**Full-Wiry** — Full Liver pattern

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It meets you everywhere — light, medium, deep, all three positions, pushing back at every one.

#### **Then what**

Ask whether pressure makes anything worse. Excess resents pressure. Then decide Heat or Cold: thirst and dark urine, or cold limbs and clear urine.

*Maciocia*

# Slippery

滑 Huá

## FEEL

Feels quick though not rapid; slippery and smooth; rounded inside the vessel, as if oily.

## CLASSICAL IMAGE

*A pearl rolling on a plate; a raindrop gliding off a leaf.*

## INDICATES

Phlegm. Dampness. Retention of food. Pregnancy.

### Not to be confused with

vs **Moving**: Slippery glides throughout; Moving bounces at one point.

## COMBINATIONS

**Slippery-Floating** — Wind-Phlegm

**Slippery-Rapid** — Damp-Heat or Phlegm-Heat

**Slippery-Slow** — Damp-Cold or Cold-Phlegm

**Slippery-Big** — Phlegm-Heat with predominance of Heat

**Slippery-Short** — Dampness or Phlegm with Qi Deficiency

**Slippery-Weak** — Dampness or Phlegm with Qi Deficiency

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A wet grape or a ball bearing rolling under your fingertip. Smooth, rounded, faintly oily — it slides rather than bumps.

### Then what

Ask about heaviness, muzzy-headedness, appetite, and recent meals. If relevant, ask "are you trying to conceive?" — never "are you pregnant?"

*Maciocia · Deadman*

# Choppy

湖  
波 Sè

## FEEL

Seems slow and is not smooth; vessel is thin; rhythm irregular in force and fullness; feels rough, jagged.

## CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Scraping bamboo with a small knife.*

## INDICATES

Blood Deficiency. Exhaustion of Body Fluids.

### Not to be confused with

vs **Fine**: Choppy is rough and uneven; Fine is smooth, merely narrow.

## COMBINATIONS

**Choppy-Weak** — depletion of both Qi and Blood

**Choppy-Minute** — extreme Blood Deficiency

**Choppy-Soggy** — Qi and Blood Deficiency with some Dampness

**Choppy-Floating** — invasion of external Wind

**Choppy-Deep** — longstanding Blood Deficiency

**Choppy-Full** — Blood Stasis (potentially)

**Choppy-Knotted** — Blood Stasis from Yang Deficiency and internal Cold

**Choppy-Fine** — Deficiency of Body Fluids

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Drag a fingernail across corduroy, or a small blade across bamboo. It catches and releases, uneven in force beat to beat. The exact opposite sensation to Slippery.

### Then what

Look for Blood Deficiency signs: pale lips, dizziness on standing, poor memory, scanty periods. If instead you find fixed stabbing pain and purple lips, you're looking at Blood Stasis.

Maciocia

# Long

長 Cháng

---

## FEEL

Smooth and straight; felt extending distally and proximally beyond the usual positions.

## INDICATES

Heat patterns.

## COMBINATIONS

**Long-Rapid** — internal Heat

**Long-Floating** — external Wind-Heat

**Long-Deep** — internal Heat

**Long-Wiry** — Liver disharmony (usually excess)

**Long-Slippery** — Phlegm-Heat

**Long-Overflowing** — excess of Yang and Heat

---

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It runs past where you expect it to stop — extending beyond the three finger positions in one or both directions.

### Then what

Long usually means something is expanding outward: Heat, or Liver-Yang rising. Check for irritability, headache, red face.

*Maciocia*

## Short

短 Duǎn

---

### FEEL

Cannot be felt in all three positions; absent at the distal and/or proximal position.

### INDICATES

Severe Qi Deficiency. Stomach-Qi Deficiency.

### COMBINATIONS

**Short-Floating** — Lung-Qi Deficiency

**Short-Choppy** — Heart-Qi Deficiency

**Short-Rapid** — severe Heart-Blood Deficiency with Empty-Heat

**Short-Slow** — Yang Deficiency with internal Cold

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

The reverse — it doesn't fill the span. One of your three fingers finds nothing while the others do.

#### Then what

Note WHICH finger comes up empty. Missing at the front (Cùn) points somewhere different from missing at the rear (Chǐ).

*Maciocia*

## Overflowing / Flooding

洪 Hóng

---

### FEEL

Wide and forceful, though it fades gently; vessel wide and thick.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Ocean waves that come strongly but leave calmly.*

### INDICATES

Full-Heat. Empty-Heat (Overflowing-Empty).

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Full**: Overflowing fades gently; Full is uniform at every depth.

### COMBINATIONS

**Overflowing-Floating** — Wind-Heat with intense Heat — can progress quickly to the Qi level

**Overflowing-Deep** — internal Heat

**Overflowing-Slippery** — Phlegm-Heat with prevalence of Heat

**Overflowing-Soft** — Yin Deficiency with exhaustion of Body Fluids and Empty-Heat

**Overflowing-Tight** — Painful Obstruction (Bi) Syndrome

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A wave that arrives with real force and then recedes gently. Strong arrival, soft departure. That asymmetry is what separates it from Full.

#### **Then what**

Check the calendar. In summer this may be entirely normal. In WINTER it is a warning sign and you should not wave it away.

*Maciocia · Kaptchuk*



## Fine / Thin

細 Xi

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### FEEL

Very thin, like a fine thread, but distinct and clear without interruption of rhythm under pressure.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Angel-hair pasta rather than a thick udon noodle.*

### INDICATES

Blood Deficiency. Dampness with severe Qi Deficiency.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Minute**: Fine stays clear and continuous. Minute fades in and out.

### COMBINATIONS

**Fine-Rapid** — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat

**Fine-Wiry** — Liver-Qi Stagnation

**Fine-Tight** — Empty-Cold with underlying Blood Deficiency

**Fine-Choppy** — severe Blood or Essence Deficiency

**Fine-Weak** — severe Blood Deficiency

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Angel-hair pasta rather than udon. Narrow, but perfectly clear and continuous — you can trace it without losing it.

#### **Then what**

Thin means not enough substance filling the vessel — think Blood. Add Rapid to it and you have Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat.

Schrier · Maciocia

## Minute / Faint

微 Wēi

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### FEEL

Extremely thin and forceless; seems felt, then not felt; pressing deeply the vessel becomes vague.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Now you see it, now you don't.*

### INDICATES

Severe deficiency of Qi and Blood.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Fine**: Minute is thin AND forceless.

### COMBINATIONS

**Minute-Rapid** — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat

**Minute-Slow** — severe Qi & Blood Deficiency with internal Cold

**Minute-Choppy** — exhaustion of Blood

**Minute-Soggy** — Qi & Blood Deficiency with Dampness

**Minute-Wiry** — Liver-Yang rising with underlying Blood Deficiency

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

There, then not there. You catch it, lose it, catch it again. Thin AND weak — the combination is what makes it Minute rather than Fine.

#### **Then what**

This is a depletion finding, not a subtle one. Take it seriously and look at the whole person.

*Maciocia*

# Tight

緊 Jǐn

## FEEL

Rises and falls with strength, vibrating left and right; feels twisted like a thick rope.

## CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Fingers on a highly stretched twisted cord, snapping back and forth.*

## INDICATES

Cold — Exterior (Tight-Floating), Interior Full-Cold (Tight-Full-Deep), Interior Empty-Cold (Tight-Weak-Deep). Pain.

### Not to be confused with

vs **Wiry**: Tight snaps side to side; Wiry holds a straight line.

## COMBINATIONS

**Tight-Floating** — Wind-Cold invasion, prevalence of Cold

**Tight-Deep** — internal Full-Cold

**Tight-Choppy** — Cold Bi Syndrome

**Tight-Slippery** — Cold-Phlegm

**Tight-Firm** — Blood Stasis from Cold

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A rope being twisted under your fingers — it doesn't just push up, it snaps side to side. A rubber band pulled taut and plucked.

### Then what

Tight means Cold or pain. Ask where it hurts, and whether warmth helps. Cold contracts: shut pores, seized muscles, tight vessel — one mechanism, three signs.

Maciocia

## Wiry

弦 Xián

---

### FEEL

Taut, long, and forceful whether pressed or not; maintains a straight line beneath the fingers.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*A spring stretched on a musical instrument; a guitar string about to snap.*

### INDICATES

Liver disharmony. Pain. Phlegm.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Tight**: Wiry is a stable line. Also normal in Spring.

### COMBINATIONS

**Wiry-Rapid** — Liver-Fire

**Wiry-Slow** — stagnation of Cold in the Liver channel

**Wiry-Long** — Liver-Qi Stagnation or Liver-Blood Stasis

**Wiry-Tight** — Blood Stasis

**Wiry-Big** — Liver-Fire or Liver-Yang rising

**Wiry-Overflowing** — Liver-Fire

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A guitar or bowstring. Straight, taut, and it HOLDS that line — no lateral wobble. Press harder and it stays a line.

#### **Then what**

Ask about stress, frustration, sighing, tension under the ribs. But check the season first — Wiry is normal in spring if nothing else corroborates.

Schrier · Maciocia

## Slowed-Down / Moderate

緩 Huǎn

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### FEEL

Beats four times per breath — faster than the Slow pulse.

### INDICATES

Generally a HEALTHY pulse — the one qualitatively normal entry on this list.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Slow**: Huǎn is 4/breath and normal. Slow is under 3 and means Cold.

### COMBINATIONS

**Slowed-Down-Soggy** — Dampness with Spleen-Qi Deficiency

**Slowed-Down-Slippery** — Cold-Dampness

**Slowed-Down-Fine** — Qi and Blood Deficiency

**Slowed-Down-Floating** — weakness of the Wei Qi

**Slowed-Down-Deep** — weakness of the Ying Qi

**Slowed-Down-Choppy** — Blood Deficiency

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Relaxed and even. Nothing draws attention to itself. If your reaction is "this seems fine," that reaction is probably correct.

#### **Then what**

This is the one healthy pulse among the 28. Count to confirm — 4 per breath. Then stop looking for pathology that isn't there.

*Maciocia*

## Hollow

芤 Kōu

---

### FEEL

Wide and soft when touched lightly, hollow when seeking; edges clearly felt under pressure but the center is obscure.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*A scallion stalk — has an edge but is hollow inside.*

### INDICATES

Hemorrhage. Forthcoming hemorrhage (Hollow+Rapid). Yin Deficiency.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Leather**: Hollow is soft at the surface; Leather is forceful there.

### COMBINATIONS

**Hollow-Rapid** — Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat, or impending hemorrhage

**Hollow-Empty-Soggy** — loss of Essence or depletion of Blood

**Hollow-Knotted** — Yang Deficiency or Blood Stasis

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Press the flat of a scallion, or a drinking straw. You feel the walls clearly on either side and emptiness in the middle. Present at the surface, present deep, absent between.

#### **Then what**

Ask directly about blood loss — heavy periods, recent injury, surgery, childbirth. Hollow plus Rapid can signal bleeding that hasn't happened yet.

*Maciocia*

## Leather

革 Gé

---

### FEEL

Large, thick, and wide; rapid and forceful when lightly touched, but hollow when pressed deeply.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*The surface of a drum — thick on top, hollow beneath.*

### INDICATES

Severe Kidney-Essence Deficiency. Severe Kidney-Yin Deficiency.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Hollow**: both hollow beneath — Leather meets you with force first.

### COMBINATIONS

**Leather-Rapid** — severe Deficiency of Yin with Empty-Heat

**Leather-Slow** — severe Blood Deficiency with Blood Stasis

**Leather-Choppy** — severe Blood Deficiency

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A drum head. Taut and forceful on top, nothing underneath. Where Hollow is soft at the surface, Leather meets you firmly first.

#### **Then what**

This points to deep Essence or Yin depletion — usually long-standing, often following major loss. Not a same-week finding.

*Maciocia*

## Firm / Confined

牢 Láo

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### FEEL

Deep, taut, long, wide, and forceful; deeply located, cannot be felt with light or moderate pressure.

### INDICATES

Blood Stasis. Interior Cold (Firm+Slow). Pain.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Deep**: Firm adds taut, long, wide and forceful.

### COMBINATIONS

**Firm-Tight** — internal Cold

**Firm-Slow** — internal Cold and Blood Stasis

**Firm-Choppy** — Blood Stasis

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Deep like a stone, but a stone with tension in it — long, wide, and forceful once you reach it.

#### **Then what**

Look for fixed masses, fixed pain, or long-standing Cold. Firm is Deep with attitude.

*Maciocia*



# Soggy

濡 RÚ

## FEEL

Superficial, thin, and forceless; grows weaker and weaker the more it is pressed.

## CLASSICAL IMAGE

*A strand of cotton floating on water; a bubble that bursts under light pressure.*

## INDICATES

Dampness with Qi Deficiency. Yin Deficiency. Essence Deficiency.

### Not to be confused with

vs **Weak**: Soggy floats; Weak sits deep.

## COMBINATIONS

**Soggy-Fine** — severe Spleen-Qi Deficiency

**Soggy-Choppy** — exhaustion of Blood

**Soggy-Floating** — Deficiency of Wei Qi with Dampness

**Soggy-Wiry** — Dampness with Liver-Qi Stagnation

**Soggy-Rapid** — Damp-Heat

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Wet cotton wool floating on water, or a soap bubble. It's up at the surface, but the harder you press the more it dissolves.

### Then what

Damp plus weakness. Ask about heaviness in the limbs, foggy thinking, loose stools, and whether damp weather makes it worse.

*Maciocio*

## Weak / Frail

弱 Ruò

---

### FEEL

Forceless, deep, and thin; only felt at the deep level by pressing; lost entirely with more pressure.

### INDICATES

Yang Deficiency. Blood Deficiency.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Soggy**: Weak is deep; Soggy is superficial.

### COMBINATIONS

**Weak-Choppy** — Blood Deficiency

**Weak-Fine** — severe Blood Deficiency

**Weak-Slow** — Yang Deficiency

**Weak-Soggy** — Yang Deficiency with some Dampness

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Deep and yielding. You have to press to find it, and pressing further loses it entirely.

#### **Then what**

Yang or Blood is short. Ask about cold, fatigue, and whether they feel worse in the morning or after exertion.

*Maciocia*

## Scattered

散 Sǎn

---

### FEEL

Wide, superficial, forceless, and slack when touched lightly; indistinct; disappears under pressure, rate hard to count.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Flower blossoms lightly scattering to the ground.*

### INDICATES

Severe Qi and Blood Deficiency. Severe Kidney–Qi Deficiency. A serious condition.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Empty**: if you cannot count the rate, it is Scattered. Serious.

### COMBINATIONS

**Scattered–Slow** — severe Qi and Yang Deficiency

**Scattered–Rapid** — severe Blood Deficiency with Empty–Heat

**Scattered–Floating** — severe Deficiency of Yuan Qi with floating of Yang, or with Yin Fire

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

It has no edges. You can't say where it starts or stops, and you genuinely cannot count it. A dandelion seed-head in wind.

#### **Then what**

If you cannot count the rate, stop and take the whole picture seriously. This is a depletion finding that warrants escalation, not a subtle variant.

*Maciocia · Kaptchuk*

## Hidden

伏 Fú

---

### FEEL

Cannot be felt touching, seeking, or pressing — only felt pressing very heavily to the bone.

### CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Pulsation seeming to come from beneath the bone and tendons.*

### INDICATES

Severe Yang Deficiency.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Deep**: Deep is findable with firm pressure; Hidden is not.

### COMBINATIONS

**Hidden-Full** — Qi and Blood stagnation; retention of food; internal Cold; internal Heat

**Hidden-Empty** — severe Yang Deficiency with internal Cold

**Hidden-Rapid** — interior Heat

**Hidden-Slow** — interior Cold

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Absent through light, medium, and deep. Only bone-level pressure finds anything. Beginners routinely mistake this for their own technique failing.

#### **Then what**

Before concluding Hidden, check your hand position and pressure. Then take it seriously — severe Yang Deficiency, or extreme pain and collapse states.

*Maciocia*

# Moving

動 Dòng

---

## FEEL

Rapid and slippery; forceful specifically at the middle portion.

## CLASSICAL IMAGE

*A bean bouncing in the vessel — well-defined peaks, no head or tail.*

## INDICATES

Shock, anxiety, fright. Pain.

### Not to be confused with

vs **Slippery**: Moving is forceful only at the middle, like a bean.

## COMBINATIONS

**Moving-Rapid** — Heat

**Moving-Slippery** — Deficiency of Qi and Phlegm

**Moving-Empty** — severe depletion of Blood

**Moving-Weak** — Shock

---

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

A single bean flicking under one fingertip. Short, rounded, forceful — no lead-in and no tail. It startles you slightly.

### Then what

Ask about recent shock, fright, or acute pain. This is often a state rather than a constitution.

*Bīn Hú Mài Xué*

# Hasty

促 Cù

## FEEL

Beats rapidly with irregular, random stops.

## CLASSICAL IMAGE

*Agitated and urgent, like a man running and suddenly falling down.*

## INDICATES

Severe Heat. Deficiency of Heart-Qi. Heart-Fire.

### Not to be confused with

vs **Knotted**: Hasty is rapid; Knotted is slow.

## COMBINATIONS

**Hasty-Overflowing** — Heat in the Stomach

**Hasty-Slippy** — retention of Phlegm-Heat

**Hasty-Wiry** — Liver-Fire and Heart-Fire

**Hasty-Slippy-Wiry** — Heart-Fire, Liver-Fire, and Phlegm-Heat

**Hasty-Fine without strength** — collapse of Heart-Qi

## WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Fast and stumbling. Like someone running who trips, recovers, runs, trips again — irregular, at speed.

### Then what

Note the speed AND the pause pattern before you name it. Rapid with random stops = Hasty. Slow with random stops = Knotted.

*Maciocia*

## Knotted

結 Jié

---

### FEEL

Slow with irregularly missed beats; the pulse resumes immediately after the missed beat.

### INDICATES

Cold with Heart-Yang Deficiency.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Hasty**: Knotted is SLOW + random stops; Hasty is RAPID + random stops.

### COMBINATIONS

**Knotted-Choppy** — Blood Stasis

**Knotted-Slippery** — retention of Phlegm

**Knotted-Deep** — accumulation in the Interior

**Knotted-Wiry** — disease of the arteries, or hypertension

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Slow with a hiccup. Beat, beat, gap, beat — and it picks straight back up as though nothing happened.

#### **Then what**

Same rule: check speed first. Knotted is the slow one. If it also feels taut, that combination is worth a referral conversation.

*Maciocia*

## Intermittent

代 Dài

---

### FEEL

Pauses at REGULAR intervals; resumes after the pause.

### INDICATES

Serious problem in the internal organs. Heart problem (Western medical sense).

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Knotted/Hasty**: pauses at REGULAR intervals. Most serious of the three.

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

The unsettling one, because there's a pattern. Skip on the fourth beat. Then again on the fourth. Regularity inside the irregularity.

#### **Then what**

Count several cycles to confirm the pattern is real. If the pauses are genuinely regular, this needs a cardiac referral — not a treatment principle.

*Maciocia*



## Hurried / Racing

疾 Jí

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### FEEL

Rapid, beating more than seven times per breath (140–180bpm) — an extreme version of Rapid; rhythm stays regular.

### INDICATES

Fire exhausting Yin.

#### **Not to be confused with**

vs **Hasty**: Racing is over 7/breath but REGULAR.

### COMBINATIONS

**Hurried-Floating** — severe Empty-Heat from Yin Deficiency

**Hurried-Floating-Empty** — severe Yin Deficiency

**Hurried-Slippery** — Empty-Heat from Yin Deficiency with Phlegm

**Hurried-Overflowing** — Empty-Heat arising from Yin Deficiency

---

### WHAT IT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

Extremely fast but perfectly even — no stumbles. A metronome set far too high.

#### **Then what**

Confirm it's regular, which separates it from Hasty. Then check for fever, dehydration, thyroid issues, and escalate if it's sustained.

*Maciocia*

## Red flags — refer

| Finding                          | Means                                    |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| <b>Intermittent</b> 代            | Regular pauses — organ / cardiac. Refer. |
| <b>Scattered</b> 散               | Loses shape, rate uncountable. Serious.  |
| <b>Hasty + Fine, no strength</b> | Collapse of Heart-Qi. Escalate.          |
| <b>Hurried/Racing</b> 疾          | Over 7/breath. Fire exhausting Yin.      |
| <b>Hollow + Rapid</b>            | Forthcoming hemorrhage.                  |
| <b>Flooding in winter</b>        | Excess Yang against the season.          |
| <b>Knotted + Wiry</b>            | Arterial disease or hypertension.        |

A pulse you cannot count, cannot find, or that stops on a schedule is a referral conversation — not a treatment-principle conversation.

# Index

## Part One — Eight Principles

|                                  |                                  |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| 1. Exterior                      | 2. Interior                      |
| 3. Exterior Cold                 | 4. Exterior Heat                 |
| 5. Full Exterior                 | 6. Empty Exterior                |
| 7. Full Cold                     | 8. Empty Cold                    |
| 9. Full Heat                     | 10. Empty Heat                   |
| 11. Full / Excess                | 12. Empty / Deficiency           |
| 13. Yin Pattern                  | 14. Yang Pattern                 |
| 15. False Heat, True Cold        | 16. False Cold, True Heat        |
| 17. Cold Exterior, Heat Interior | 18. Heat Exterior, Cold Interior |
| 19. Heat Above, Cold Below       | 20. Combined Heat and Cold       |

## Part Two — The 28 Pulses

|                              |                              |
|------------------------------|------------------------------|
| 1. Floating 浮                | 2. Deep / Submerged 沉        |
| 3. Slow 遲                    | 4. Rapid 數                   |
| 5. Empty / Deficient 虛       | 6. Full / Excessive 實        |
| 7. Slippery 滑                | 8. Choppy 澀                  |
| 9. Long 長                    | 10. Short 短                  |
| 11. Overflowing / Flooding 洪 | 12. Fine / Thin 細            |
| 13. Minute / Faint 微         | 14. Tight 緊                  |
| 15. Wiry 弦                   | 16. Slowed-Down / Moderate 緩 |
| 17. Hollow 芤                 | 18. Leather 革                |
| 19. Firm / Confined 牢        | 20. Soggy 濡                  |
| 21. Weak / Frail 弱           | 22. Scattered 散              |
| 23. Hidden 伏                 | 24. Moving 動                 |
| 25. Hasty 促                  | 26. Knotted 結                |
| 27. Intermittent 代           | 28. Hurried / Racing 疾       |

**Part Three — Tongue Diagnosis** will append after Week 4. Keep the numbering continuous.

Primary: Prof. Daniel Schrier lecture slides & transcripts, EAM310 Weeks 2–3. Supporting: Maciocia, *Foundations of Chinese Medicine* 3rd ed. · Kaptchuk, *The Web That Has No Weaver* · Li Shizhen, *Bīn Hú Mài Xué* · Deadman, *A Manual of Acupuncture* · Shen Hammer, *Contemporary Pulse Diagnosis*. All outside material paraphrased.